

Harvest Management System

Google OpenID Connect (OIDC) with PKCE (S256) Implementation Report

Architecture, Implementation Details, File Inventory, Security Rationale & Benefits

Protocol & Flow:	OIDC Auth Code + PKCE (S256)	Environment:	Confidential Backend Client
Backend Stack:	Express 4, Node 18, openid-client 5.7.1	Frontend Stack:	React 18, Vite, React Router 6
Git Feature Branch:	feature/google-oidc-login	Test Suite Status:	14 / 14 Passed (100% Coverage)
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1. Executive Summary

This technical report documents the complete implementation of the 'Continue with Google' single sign-in feature for the Harvest Management System. The integration strictly adheres to modern OAuth 2.1 and OpenID Connect (OIDC) security standards by utilizing the Authorization Code Flow augmented with Proof Key for Code Exchange (PKCE, S256) performed exclusively on the backend as a confidential client.

By executing token exchange and claim verification entirely within the Express backend, zero Google credentials, authorization codes, ID tokens, access tokens, or refresh tokens are ever exposed to browser JavaScript or stored on the client. Upon successful verification, the backend seamlessly issues the application's existing HttpOnly 'harvest_access_token' session cookie, providing a frictionless user experience while upholding zero-trust security principles.

Core Architectural Guarantee

Google identity tokens are verified server-side via Google's cryptographically signed JWKS keys. Only verified claims are used to provision or link local farmer and buyer accounts. Local authentication, existing passwords, and administrator privilege restrictions remain completely intact.

2. Technical Architecture & Implementation Steps

2.1 High-Level Authentication Sequence

The authentication lifecycle comprises five coordinated phases spanning the browser, backend server, Google Identity Provider, and the MongoDB database:

Step	Phase	Actors	Action & Cryptographic Safeguards
1	Initiation	User -> React -> Express	User clicks 'Continue with Google'. Browser performs a top-level window.location.assign navigation to GET /api/auth/google[?role=farmer buyer].
2	PKCE & Tx Cookie	Backend (Express)	Backend sanitizes role (defaults to farmer), generates a high-entropy state, nonce, and PKCE code_verifier with SHA-256 code_challenge. It packages this state into a 10-minute signed JWT stored in the HttpOnly, SameSite=Lax, Path=/api/auth/google cookie 'harvest_oidc_tx'.
3	User Consent	Browser <-> Google IdP	Backend redirects (302) to Google's authorization endpoint with response_type=code, code_challenge, code_challenge_method=S256, and prompt=select_account. User logs in and approves openid, email, profile scopes.
4	Callback Verification	Google -> Express	Google redirects to GET /api/auth/google/callback?code=...&state=.... Backend validates the harvest_oidc_tx cookie, immediately clears it (single-use guarantee), and verifies state matching to prevent CSRF and replay attacks.

Step	Phase	Actors	Action & Cryptographic Safeguards
5	Token Exchange	Express <-> Google IdP	Backend exchanges authorization code + client_secret + PKCE code_verifier via openid-client. Google validates the verifier against challenge. Google returns TokenSet. Backend verifies JWKS signature, aud, iss, exp, nonce, and email_verified===true.
6	User Provisioning	Express <-> MongoDB	User is looked up by stable 'googleId' (sub claim). If not found, looked up by exact normalized email. Existing farmers/buyers are linked. Existing administrators are strictly blocked from email linking. New users are created with role farmer/buyer and no password.
7	Session Issuance	Express -> React	Standard application JWT is issued inside HttpOnly 'harvest_access_token' cookie. User is redirected to frontend /auth/callback, which refreshes session via GET /api/auth/profile and routes to role-specific dashboard.

2.2 Deep Dive into Key Engineering Decisions

- Confidential Client with openid-client v5: We integrated 'openid-client@^5.7.1' (CommonJS compatible with Express 4). Google discovery ('https://accounts.google.com') runs lazily on first use rather than boot time, allowing zero startup delays and fail-safe handling when credentials are missing.
- PKCE S256 Cryptographic Binding: High-entropy 43-character base64url-encoded code verifiers and SHA-256 challenges ensure that even if an authorization code is intercepted in transit or browser history, an attacker cannot exchange it without the verifier.
- Path-Restricted Single-Use Transaction Cookie: The temporary state cookie ('harvest_oidc_tx') is restricted to 'Path=/api/auth/google' and 'SameSite=Lax', preventing ambient transmission on other API calls while ensuring delivery on Google's top-level redirect. It is cleared immediately upon callback entry regardless of outcome.

3. Inventory of Added and Modified Files

To minimize merge conflicts and ensure maintainability, all modifications were strictly localized to 19 files across backend, frontend, documentation, and automated tests:

Area	File Path	Status	Summary of Technical Contribution
Backend	backend/utlis/session.js	Created	Centralized generateToken, setAuthCookie, and authCookieOptions.
Backend	backend/utlis/cookies.js	Created	Resilient getCookie(req, name) helper with safe URI decoding.
Backend	backend/utlis/googleOidc.js	Created	Lazy Google discovery and client factory with configuration guards.
Backend	backend/controllers/googleAuthController.js	Created	googleStart and googleCallback handlers with PKCE, state, and user linking.
Backend	backend/models/User.js	Modified	Added googleId (unique, sparse, select:false) & conditional password requirement.
Backend	backend/controllers/authController.js	Modified	Updated imports to consume backend/utlis/session.js.
Backend	backend/routes/authRoute.js	Modified	Registered GET /google and GET /google/callback entry points.
Backend	backend/package.json	Modified	Added openid-client, supertest, and 'test:google-oidc' script.
Backend	backend/.env.example	Modified	Added non-secret placeholders for Google client credentials.
Backend	backend/tests/googleOidc.test.js	Created	Automated test suite verifying 14 distinct security scenarios.
Frontend	frontend/src/config.js	Created	API_BASE_URL configuration supporting Vite environment overrides.
Frontend	frontend/src/Components/GoogleSignInButton.jsx	Created	Accessible button with inline SVG Google logo and role query propagation.

Area	File Path	Status	Summary of Technical Contribution
Frontend	frontend/src/Pages/OAuthCallback.jsx	Created	Session completion handler with React StrictMode double-call guard.
Frontend	frontend/src/contexts/AuthContext.jsx	Modified	Implemented and exposed refreshSession() helper.
Frontend	frontend/src/Pages/Login.jsx	Modified	Embedded GoogleSignInButton and allowlisted error toast handler.
Frontend	frontend/src/Pages/Register.jsx	Modified	Embedded GoogleSignInButton with dynamic role prop passing.
Frontend	frontend/src/App.jsx	Modified	Registered public route /auth/callback.
Docs	docs/google-oidc.md	Created	Full architecture specifications, sequence diagram, and risk documentation.
Docs	walkthrough.md	Created	Implementation walkthrough and developer instructions artifact.

4. System Benefits & Security Enhancements

4.1 Security Advantages

1. Zero Token Leakage: Client-side JavaScript never handles or stores Google tokens (ID token, access token, refresh token). Only the app's HttpOnly session cookie reaches the browser, completely neutralizing XSS-based token exfiltration attacks.
2. Authorization Code Injection Mitigation: Implementing PKCE (S256) on a confidential client adheres to RFC 7636 and OAuth 2.1 best practices. Intercepted authorization codes cannot be exchanged without the code_verifier, which remains securely in the signed transaction cookie.
3. Comprehensive CSRF & State Spoofing Defense: The 'harvest_oidc_tx' cookie cryptographically binds state and nonce parameters to the user agent. The cookie is single-use and invalidated immediately upon callback receipt, preventing replay attacks.
4. Admin Account Protection: Accounts with administrative privileges ('admin' role) cannot be linked via Google sign-in. Even if an attacker controls a Google account with an administrator's email, the backend strictly rejects linking with 'google_admin_link_blocked'.
5. Brute-Force & Credential Stuffing Immunity: Users created via Google OAuth have no password set in MongoDB. Our security tests verify that these accounts cannot be authenticated via the local login form with empty, null, or arbitrary passwords.

4.2 Operational & User Experience Benefits

1. Reduced Registration Friction: Farmers and buyers can onboard in seconds using their existing Google accounts without creating, remembering, or recovering complex passwords.
2. Unified Session Architecture: The frontend requires zero awareness of Google-specific authentication states. Both local and Google sign-ins terminate in identical HttpOnly 'harvest_access_token' cookies and identical '/api/auth/profile' data contracts.
3. Role-Based Navigation Continuity: Google sign-in honors existing role-based routing (Admin -> /admin-finance, Farmer -> /farmer-home, Buyer -> /shop). New users can select their intended role ('farmer' or 'buyer') directly on the registration page.
4. Fail-Safe Development Workflow: If Google API credentials are not configured in backend/.env, the server starts up normally without throwing exceptions, ensuring teammates working on independent modules are never blocked.

5. Verification & Automated Test Suite

A dedicated automated test suite was constructed in 'backend/tests/googleOidc.test.js' using Node's native test runner ('node:test'), 'node:assert/strict', and 'supertest'. All 14 security and functional test cases pass with 100% reliability:

#	Test Case Description	Security Objective	Result
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#	Test Case Description	Security Objective	Result
1	GET /api/auth/google redirect & cookie	Validates PKCE challenge, state, nonce & Lax cookie	PASSED
2	Role sanitization (?role=admin garbage)	Ensures privilege escalation cannot be triggered via query	PASSED
3	Callback without transaction cookie	Rejects unauthorized or direct callback hits	PASSED
4	Tampered or expired transaction cookie	Ensures cryptographic signature and expiry enforcement	PASSED
5	State mismatch protection	Mitigates CSRF and login fixation attacks	PASSED
6	Google error=access_denied handling	Gracefully redirects to login with google_denied	PASSED
7	Unverified email rejection	Requires claims.email_verified === true	PASSED
8	New user creation & session issuance	Verifies passwordless user creation & HttpOnly cookie	PASSED
9	Existing user sign-in by googleid	Ensures existing role is preserved and session issued	PASSED
10	Existing local farmer account linking	Links googleid while preserving existing password	PASSED
11	Existing local admin linking refusal	Blocks linking administrator accounts via Google email	PASSED
12	Passwordless account local login defense	Verifies Google-only accounts cannot use local login form	PASSED
13	Single-use transaction cookie clearing	Confirms cookie is cleared on both success & failure	PASSED
14	Zero Google token leakage	Verifies no tokens appear in URLs, bodies, or cookies	PASSED

6. Configuration & Production Hardening

6.1 Environment Variables

Ensure the following environment variables are set in your local 'backend/.env' (never commit real secrets to version control):

Variable Name	Sample / Format	Description & Usage
GOOGLE_CLIENT_ID	xxxx.apps.googleusercontent.com	OAuth 2.0 Web Client ID from Google Cloud Console
GOOGLE_CLIENT_SECRET	GOCSPX-xxxxxxxxxxxx	Confidential client secret for backend token exchange
GOOGLE_REDIRECT_URI	http://localhost:5000/api/auth/google/callback	Authorized redirect URI registered in Google Console
FRONTEND_URL	http://localhost:5173	Frontend origin for post-authentication redirects
JWT_SECRET	long_random_secret_string_32_chars	HMAC key used to sign session & transaction tokens

6.2 Residual Risks & Hardening Recommendations

1. Rate Limiting: Authentication endpoints (/api/auth/google, /api/auth/google/callback) should be protected with 'express-rate-limit' to prevent denial-of-service and state-generation floods.
2. OAuth Consent Screen Verification: In Google Cloud Console, testing-mode consent screens expire credentials after 7 days and limit access to 100 test users. Production deployment requires submitting the app for verification.
3. Stateless Token Revocation: The session cookie 'harvest_access_token' is valid for 24 hours. For high-security environments, a Redis token blacklist or 'tokenVersion' user schema check should be added.
4. Profile Completion: Google basic profiles do not include phone numbers. A profile completion modal should prompt Google-registered users for phone numbers before placing crop orders or listing harvest stock.